

English is a Thief

Where do English words really come from?

Global English · group presentation · 9/14

[your names here]



THE QUESTION

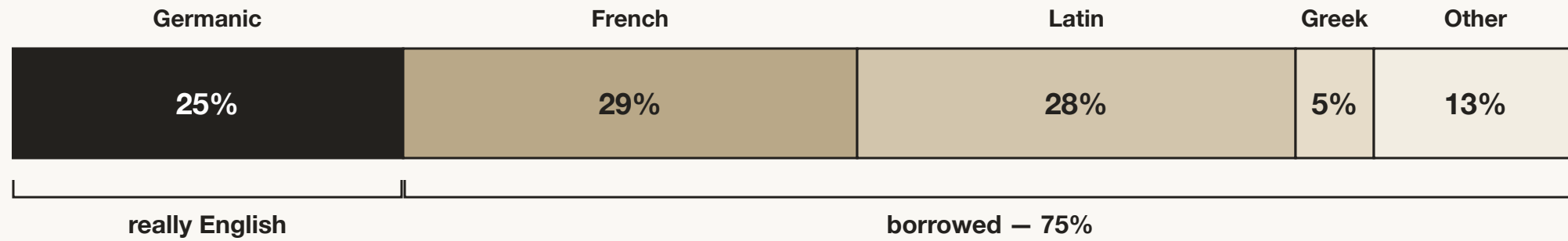
**English has about
170,000 words.**

But how many of them are *really* English?



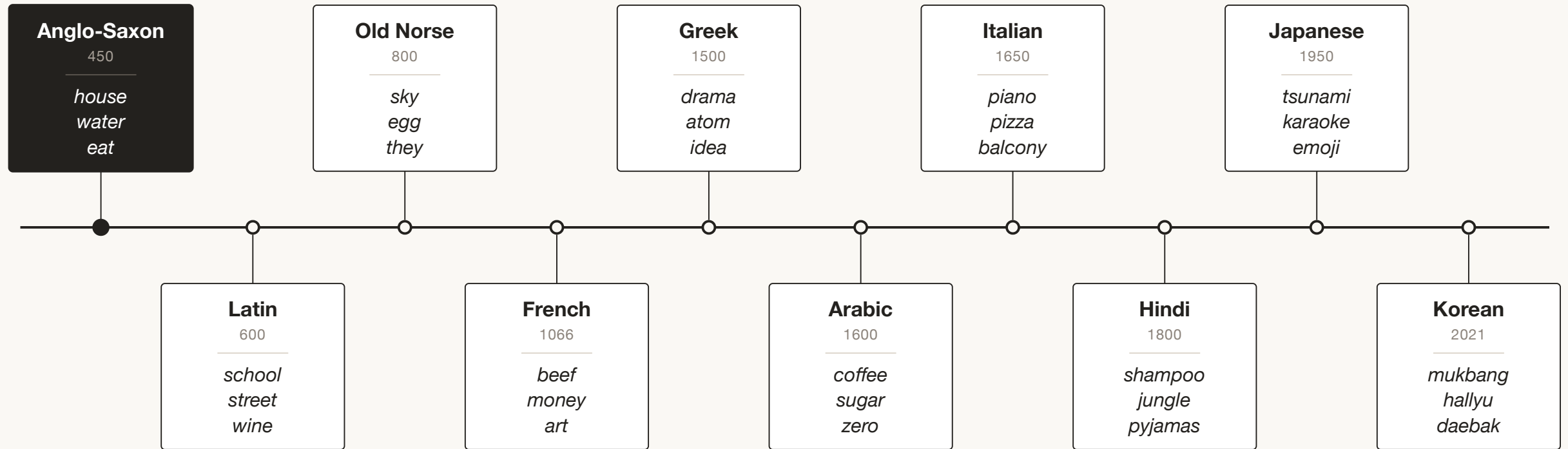
THE ANSWER

Only 1 word in 4.



Where the words in a big English dictionary come from. Numbers: Finkenstaedt & Wolff, *Ordered Profusion* (1973), about 80,000 words. But careful: the words we use *every day* — *the, is, man, water* — are still the old English ones. English borrowed the *big* vocabulary, not the basics.

So who did English steal from?



Black box = the original English. Everything else came later. Dates are roughly when the words arrived — not to scale.

Then they stayed.

They attacked England for 200 years, and then they lived there. The two languages mixed. English kept their words:

sky

egg

knife

window

husband

law

skin

ugly

window is Old Norse *vindauga* — “wind-eye”. A hole for the wind.

And English also took these:

they

them

their

Most languages *never* borrow words like this. English did.



William the Conqueror wins. For the next 300 years the kings of England speak French. The farmers keep speaking English.

IN THE FIELD — ENGLISH

ON THE TABLE — FRENCH

cow

beef

pig

pork

sheep

mutton

deer

venison

The poor kept the animals. The rich ate them.

1,000 years later we still use both words.



with tea, cotton — and words.

shampoo

Hindi *chāmpo* — “to press, to massage”

pyjamas

Hindi / Persian — “leg clothes”

jungle

Hindi *jaṅgal*

bungalow

Hindi — “a house in the Bengal style”

safari

Swahili — “journey”

tea

Chinese (Min Nan) *tû*

This is how English became a world language.
Not because it is easy — because of ships and
power.

QUIZ

Where is this word from?

click a word to see the answer

ketchup

chocolate

sofa

robot

tsunami

zero

English is still stealing. Right now. From us.

September 2021: the Oxford English Dictionary
added **26 Korean words** at once.

hallyu

mukbang

oppa

unni

daebak

skinship

chimaek

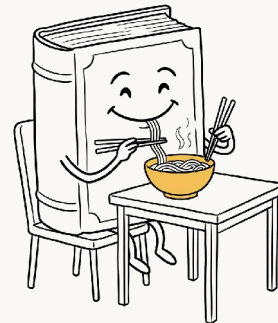
manhwa

banchan

K-drama

konglish

1,000 years ago it was the Vikings.
Today it is Korea.



And Korea makes its own English.

hand phone

one-shot

eye shopping

skinship

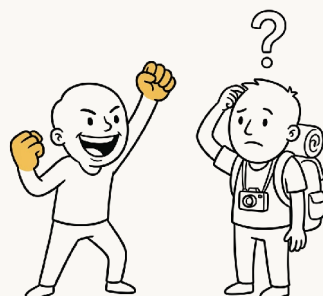
fighting!

apart

An American would not understand these.

50 million Koreans do.

So — is this wrong English? Or is it just Korean English?



English is a thief.

That is exactly why it belongs to everybody.

Thank you. Any questions?

